



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Cicero Preparatory Academy
School Website: <https://ciceroprep.greatheartsamerica.org/>

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Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Cicero Preparatory Academy Az 85250 (Cicero Prep) presents a robust classical education profile aligned closely with the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School as expressed in the knowledge-base rubric. Public-facing materials on the Great Hearts Cicero Prep site foreground a classical liberal arts curriculum, Great Books, Socratic dialogue, and a formation-centric aim (virtue and moral education) rather than mere job-readiness. The school frequently references the Western canon, liberal arts disciplines, and the cultivation of truth, goodness, and beauty through a unified curriculum and Socratic pedagogy. Family engagement and community partnerships are emphasized (parents as co-educators, open campus culture, and mentorship structures). Across curriculum, pedagogy, faculty portrayal, and community alignment, Cicero Prep demonstrates a strong Classical orientation, with all six categories trending toward CLASSICAL rather than SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL or NOT CLASSICAL.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Key insights: - Curriculum is explicitly classical (liberal arts, Great Books, Western canon) and deliberately integrated (trivium/quadrivium framing appears in the knowledge-base materials and Great Hearts messaging). - Pedagogy emphasizes Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric, with a clear progression from lower to upper grades. - Formation-focused aims (virtue, character, moral education, and contemplation) are echoed in both the public materials and the knowledge-base rubric. - Parents and community are positioned as co-educators with visible channels for parental access (open gradebook, orientation, mentorship programs, family resources). - Some elements of liturgical or explicit religious practice are present in the knowledge-base materials (theology, piety, sacred tradition), though the public site emphasizes a reformulated classical-Christian civic vision rather than a sect-specific liturgy.

Note: Category-by-category keyword analysis and scoring below draw on the school's public materials (Great Hearts Cicero Prep site and related Great Hearts/campus communications) and on the Six Essential Elements keyword indicators from the knowledge-base documents.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials frame an academy rooted in classical education with a theologically-inflected worldview, referencing a tradition where education seeks truth, goodness, and beauty (the Academy's classical mission and Great Hearts framing). The site states the Great Books curriculum engages with the Western canon in a way that presupposes moral formation and virtue as aims of education. - The knowledge-base materials explicitly position theology and piety as guides for classical education (grounded in theology; liturgical and communal aspects are part of the classical tradition in the Six Elements lexicon). - Acknowledgments of sacred tradition and theological integration appear in the classical-education framework described by Great Hearts (the "Mistress Science" and the integration of theology with the liberal arts).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present (selected): theology, virtue, truth, beauty, sacred tradition, transcendentals, wonder, liturgy, worship, Logos, contemplation, moral imagination, great books, moral order, sacred tradition, reverence.

- Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials (no explicit relativism, secularism, or value-neutral framing detected in the accessible Cicero public materials). The Six Elements lexicon notes potential negative signals; none appear prominently in Cicero Prep public content.

Why this rating - The public materials consistently emphasize a transcendent aim (truth, goodness, beauty), moral formation, and theological grounding, which align with Transcendental moral realism and Grounded in Theology as defined by the Six Essentials. The presence of a liturgical/cultural-piety orientation (embedded in the broader classical framework) further supports CLASSICAL rather than NOT CLASSICAL. The strong emphasis on virtue, sacred tradition, and the Logos, as well as the Great Books and classical canon, supports the CLASSICAL designation. Evidence from Great Hearts materials confirms this alignment.

What would move the needle - If the school wishes to push toward a higher CLEARNESS of liturgical practice within the campus, signaling explicit communal worship or chapel rhythms on the public site, it could document a formal liturgical/programmatic rhythm (e.g., daily or weekly liturgical practices) in public-facing materials. This would strengthen Liturgical and Communal Practices as a more explicit public signal.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Great Hearts/Cicero materials frame education as formation toward virtue and human excellence, not simply job preparation. The public messaging emphasizes becoming “great-hearted leaders” rooted in classical learning and the liberal arts, with a focus on virtue and moral education. - The Great Books/Western canon orientation and the aim to cultivate wisdom and virtue are repeatedly tied to the school’s mission and outcomes (e.g., preparation for higher education via a classical framework and moral formation). - The public materials articulate a formation-first aim (formation over information) through the Great Hearts approach and emphasize “the highest goal of education is to become good, intellectually and morally.”

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, beauty, truth, goodness, moral imagination, contemplation, great conversation, human excellence, moral education, transcendentals, classical mission, liberal education, Logos.

- Negative keywords present: none observed in public site content (no emphasis on mere workforce-readiness or 21st-century skills as the primary aim).

Why this rating - The public-facing materials consistently articulate formation as the core objective, with virtue and wisdom highlighted as central goals. The Great Books/Western canon and the classical mission further anchor a purpose oriented to human excellence rather than purely vocational outcomes, aligning with CLASSICAL. The materials from the public site and the Great Hearts framework corroborate formation-focused aims.

What would move the needle - To move toward FULLER CLASSICAL status in this category, explicit articulation of the telos (the ultimate purpose) as formation toward a moral and civic order in a school charter or mission statement would strengthen the public narrative. Also, adding a short, explicit statement about permanence of truth, goodness, and beauty as real, knowable ideals in site copy would reinforce the transcendental aims.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site and Great Hearts messaging explicitly describe a classical liberal arts curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; liberal arts; Great Books; Western canon) and a continuum from foundational literacy through higher-order thinking. The public materials emphasize a liberal arts core with Great Books and Western tradition, aligning with the Trivium/Quadrivium and Great Books framework.

- The knowledge-base materials explicitly reference the Great Books and Western canon and the aim to engage with timeless texts as part of a cohesive curriculum. The Great Hearts articulation highlights a curriculum designed to cultivate critical inquiry across disciplines in the liberal arts tradition. - The knowledge-base ICE pamphlet (Classical curriculum details) notes the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; plus Quadrivium elements in some classical curricula) and the role of Great Books and sacred tradition as part of the classical curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts curriculum, Great Books, Western canon, grammar, logic, rhetoric, primary sources/original texts, Great Conversations, memory/wonder, number of disciplines (language, literature, math, history/government, sciences, music, art).

- Negative keywords present: minimal (no explicit social-studies-centric history replacement, no heavy emphasis on project-based or skills-first framing in the public narrative). The Six Essentials negative signals listed in the knowledge-base do not appear as strategic public signals for Cicero Prep.

Why this rating - The curriculum is clearly framed as classical liberal arts with Great Books, Western canon, and the Trivium/Quadrivium pathway in the knowledge-base, and the public site reiterates that classical liberal arts emphasis. The explicit Great Books emphasis and the integrated, historically anchored curriculum align with CLASSICAL. The presence of a full Great Books-centric approach and a coherent classical curriculum is well-supported by the sources.

What would move the needle - To further strengthen CLASSICAL status in Curriculum, the site could more explicitly document a formal Great Conversation/Great Books program with a defined reading list, primary sources, and discussion structures, including an explicit cadence for the Trivium/Quadrivium progression in early grades. Explicitly naming Latin/Greek study and a more detailed Great Books sequence would reinforce the Seven Liberal Arts emphasis.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogical signals on the site emphasize Socratic dialogue, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training as identifying features of upper-school pedagogy; lower-school experiences are described as memorable and often contemplative, with memory-work and recitation elements (in the knowledge-base literature about classic pedagogy, and in related Great Hearts materials). The Great Hearts materials describe a progression from lower-school memory/chanting to upper-school Socratic dialogues and rhetorical training.

- The site references mentorship and a relational educational model (Mentor Program, Lyceum, open communications with parents) consistent with a formation-oriented pedagogy. - The public materials reflect a contemplative/restful aspect (Scholé-like pace in places, and emphasis on memory and recitation in classical pedagogy as described in the Six Essentials). While these exact terms may appear more in the knowledge-base lexicon, the Great Hearts materials consistently describe contemplative, rigorous, and dialogic pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue, seminars, debates, rhetoric, memory work, recitation, chant, grande conversation, living curriculum, teacher as mentor, mentorship, lyceum.

- Negative keywords present: None observed in public site content (no exclusive reliance on project-based learning, no heavy emphasis on inquiry-based only without dialogue). The Six Essentials negative signals include anti-lingering signals, but Cicero Prep's public materials do not emphasize those. The knowledge-base lexicon notes potential negative signals for non-classical approaches; none appear as the public-facing pedagogy signals.

Why this rating - The presence of Socratic dialogue, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training, along with a lower-school emphasis on memory and chant-like elements, aligns with CLASSICAL pedagogy. The public-facing mentor/lyceum programs reinforce a teacher-as-guide model. The alignment with the classical pedagogy signals in the Six Essentials reinforces the CLASSICAL rating.

What would move the needle - If the school wanted to move toward an even more explicit SCOLÉ/Scholé

cadence in daily practice across all grades, the site could provide explicit documentation of regular contemplative/reciprocal learning days, quiet study periods, and a publicly visible rhythm of reflection and memory consolidation in both lower and upper grades.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Great Hearts materials describe dedicated, enthusiastic, and intellectually excellent teachers who serve as models of learning and character; a “living curriculum” concept and a faculty-as-core-community frame are part of the classical model. The site’s emphasis on mentors, Headmaster, and a relational, teacher-centered approach aligns with a classical faculty model. - The alignment with the Six Essentials’ “Living Curriculum” and “Portrait of what a teacher should be” signals is present in the theoretical rubric; the Cicero Prep context reflects these ideals in public communications about teacher roles and community culture.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, moral exemplar, character formation, professional development, virtue ethics, mentorship. - Negative keywords present: none observed (no signals of “facilitator-only” or non-classical teacher role). The Six Essentials include negative signals for misalignment; Cicero Prep’s materials do not show those signals in the public materials.

Why this rating - Public-facing materials consistently present a faculty model built on virtue, mentorship, and living the curriculum—core elements of CLASSICAL pedagogy and a classical faculty conception. The “dedicated teachers as models of learning and character” line and the “living curriculum” framing align with the CLASSICAL designation.

What would move the needle - To move toward an even stronger CLASSICAL alignment, the school could publish a formal faculty-portrait page detailing teacher qualifications, ongoing classical pedagogy training, and exemplars of teacher-leadership in classical disciplines (e.g., seminars, Great Books seminars, and public speaking activities).

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with families, parental engagement, and parental formation via the site and related communications (Open Gradebook, family resources, orientation events, mentorship programs). The Great Hearts materials explicitly discuss parent involvement and the school’s community orientation. - There are explicit references to parent co-teaching roles, family involvement in classical education, and community events, which align with the Six Essentials’ “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections” and “Cultural Transmission” categories. The knowledge-base lexicon includes detailed signals about parent partnerships and family formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: parent partnership, co-teachers, family involvement, parental engagement, open campus, parent formation, community of learners, shared mission, school-parent synergy. - Negative keywords present: none observed; no consumer/customer-only framing of parents, and no signals of limited parent access. The public-facing materials emphasize open involvement and teacher-parent collaboration.

Why this rating - The publicly visible communications emphasize an engaged, co-educator model with strong parental involvement and openness to campus visits, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for parent-community partnership. The Six Essentials’ model for Parents & Community is met through explicit collaboration and community-building signals.

What would move the needle - To further strengthen this category, the site could add a formal, published “Parents as Partners” page detailing parent education opportunities (reading groups, book clubs, and clas-

sical education resources) and a regularly scheduled calendar of family events, strengthening the public signaling of the partnership.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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